

Outsource or Keep In-House — Customer Support • 28-Person SaaS • 600 Tickets/mo • \$18k/mo to \$12k Cap

Executive summary — 28-person SaaS company Austin B2B property management software \$4.2M ARR, 4 full-time support reps handling 600 tickets a month plus 80 chats a day covering 8am-6pm CST only no 24/7, team cost \$18k/month \$14k salary plus \$4k tools Zendesk \$500/month plus Intercom \$400/month plus manager 15 hours a week QA and escalations. Trigger: ticket backlog 48 hours after leasing module launch, CSAT dropped 3.8 from 4.6, 2 reps quit last month, churn went 2% to 3.5% monthly, support bottleneck for retention, CEO wants 24/7 and under \$12k/month. Current attempts: hiring 2 more \$45k salary each took 3 months and quit after 2 months night shifts, part-time VA Philippines \$800/month quality low wrong answers lease accounting. Considered: SupportNinja \$9k/month 24/7 team 6 with property management experience, Influx \$7.5k/month shared no dedicated team, Televerde \$12k/month US team no 24/7, keeping in-house hiring 2 more \$90k/year extra + \$4k tools = total \$25k/month over budget, friend idea outsource Tier 1 keep Tier 2 in-house. Budget \$12k hard cap \$15k perfect monthly all-in including Zendesk and Intercom vs \$18k now, monthly contract not annual, live by August 1 6 weeks before fall leasing season, need CSAT above 4.4 first response under 2 hours vs 48 hours now, escalation to product team for accounting. Must-haves: Tier 1 600 tickets 80 chats accurate lease accounting macros, 24/7 including weekends no coverage 6pm-8am now, Zendesk Slack escalation, manager 5hrs QA not 15hrs, keep 2 senior in-house Tier 2 accounting, QA reports CSAT tracking not black box, SOC2 rent data SSN security. Risks: quality drop VA \$800/mo wrong lease accounting CSAT worse, control loss churn 3.5% stays, SOC2 rent data security, hidden costs \$9k then \$3k extra QA, knowledge loss 2 reps quit no fallback, US vs Philippines brand. Success 6 months: first response under 2hrs not 48hrs, CSAT back 4.6 from 3.8, churn back 2% from 3.5%, 24/7 coverage live weekends, cost under \$12k/mo vs \$18k now all-in Zendesk \$500 + Intercom \$400, manager QA 15hrs to 5hrs, 2 senior in-house Tier 2 accounting, outsourced Tier 1 600 tickets 80 chats accurate macros, QA reports accuracy, no security incident, handled fall leasing season no backlog.

The decision

Replace in-house 4 support reps handling 600 tickets/mo plus 80 chats/day 8am-6pm only \$18k/month \$14k salary + \$4k tools Zendesk \$500 + Intercom \$400 + manager 15hrs QA with outsourced Tier 1 24/7 team handling Tier 1 tickets 600 tickets 80 chats/day accurate lease accounting macros with Zendesk Slack escalation and QA reports CSAT tracking SOC2 keeping 2 senior in-house Tier 2 for accounting questions under \$12k hard cap \$15k perfect monthly all-in including tools live by August 1 6 weeks with CSAT above 4.4 first response under 2hrs vs 48hrs now, or keep in-house 4 reps and hire 2 more \$45k each = \$90k/year extra + \$4k tools = \$25k/month total over budget if no outsourced partner meets 24/7, lease accounting accuracy, escalation, QA, SOC2, and cost criteria.

Decision maker

Founder/CEO 28-person SaaS B2B property management software \$4.2M ARR Austin — 4 support reps 600 tickets/mo 80 chats/day 8am-6pm only \$18k/month \$14k salary + \$4k tools, manager 15hrs QA, 2 reps quit last month, churn 2% to 3.5%, CSAT 3.8 from 4.6, CEO wants 24/7 under \$12k/month, fall leasing season deadline August 1.

Situation

Current: 28-person SaaS B2B property management software \$4.2M ARR Austin, 4 full-time support reps in Austin office handling 600 tickets a month plus 80 chats a day covering 8am-6pm CST only no 24/7 no weekends 6pm-8am gap, team cost \$18k/month \$14k salary plus \$4k tools — Zendesk \$500/month plus Intercom \$400/month plus manager 15 hours a week QA and escalations, backlog 48 hours after leasing module launch, CSAT dropped 3.8 from 4.6, 2 reps quit last month, churn went 2% to 3.5% monthly support bottleneck retention, hiring 2 more \$45k each took 3 months and quit after 2 months night shifts, VA Philippines \$800/month quality low wrong lease accounting answers.

Usage: Need 24/7 including weekends, Tier 1 tickets password resets how to run reports lease renewal workflow 600 tickets 80 chats/day with accurate lease accounting macros VA gave wrong before, integration Zendesk and Slack for escalation to product team accounting questions, manager wants 5 hours QA not 15 hours, keep 2 in-house senior reps Tier 2 accounting, QA reports CSAT tracking not black box, SOC2 because rent data SSN in tickets, monthly contract not annual can't lock 12 months if quality fails.

Financial: Currently \$18k/month \$14k salary + \$4k tools Zendesk \$500 + Intercom \$400, can go \$12k hard cap \$15k perfect monthly all-in including tools vs \$18k now, need live by August 1 6 weeks before fall leasing season, considered SupportNinja \$9k/month 24/7 team 6 property management experience, Influx \$7.5k/month shared no dedicated, Televerde \$12k/month US no 24/7, keeping in-house hiring 2 more \$90k/year extra + \$4k tools = \$25k/month over budget, friend idea outsource Tier 1 keep Tier 2 in-house.

Desired outcome

In 6 months first response under 2 hours not 48 hours, CSAT back to 4.6 from 3.8, churn back from 3.5% to 2% monthly, 24/7 coverage live including weekends, cost under \$12k/month vs \$18k now all-in with Zendesk \$500 + Intercom \$400, manager QA down from 15 hours to 5 hours, 2 senior in-house reps handling Tier 2 accounting questions, outsourced Tier 1 handling 600 tickets and 80 chats with accurate lease accounting macros, QA reports showing accuracy, no security incident, and we handled fall leasing season without backlog.

Prior experience

- In-house 4 reps \$18k/month \$14k salary + \$4k tools Zendesk \$500 + Intercom \$400 manager 15hrs QA — 600 tickets/mo 80 chats/day 8am-6pm only no 24/7, backlog 48hrs after leasing module, CSAT 3.8 from 4.6, 2 reps quit last month, churn 2% to 3.5%
- Hiring 2 more \$45k each = \$90k/year extra + \$4k tools = \$25k/mo — took 3 months and quit after 2 months night shifts, over \$12k cap \$15k perfect
- VA Philippines \$800/month — quality low wrong answers lease accounting, CSAT drop, no SOC2 rent data SSN
- No outsourcing yet — considered SupportNinja \$9k/mo 24/7 team 6 property mgmt exp, Influx \$7.5k shared no dedicated, Televerde \$12k US no 24/7

Priorities

- Tier 1 handling 600 tickets/mo and 80 chats/day accurate lease accounting macros — password resets, how to run reports, lease renewal workflow, not wrong answers like VA \$800/mo
- 24/7 including weekends — no coverage 6pm-8am now, need live by August 1 6 weeks before fall leasing season
- CSAT above 4.4 and first response under 2 hours vs 48 hours now, churn back 2% from 3.5%
- Zendesk + Slack escalation to product team for accounting questions, keep 2 senior in-house Tier 2
- Manager QA down 15hrs to 5hrs with QA reports CSAT tracking not black box
- SOC2 for rent data SSN security, monthly contract not annual

Constraints

- Budget \$18k now \$12k hard cap \$15k perfect monthly all-in including Zendesk \$500 + Intercom \$400, vs \$18k now \$14k salary + \$4k tools, hidden costs \$9k then \$3k extra QA worry
- Timeline live by August 1 6 weeks before fall leasing season, monthly contract not annual can't lock 12 months if quality fails
- 600 tickets/mo 80 chats/day Tier 1 accurate lease accounting — VA gave wrong answers before, need macros accurate
- Keep 2 senior in-house Tier 2 for accounting questions — can't outsource all, escalation to product needed
- SOC2 because rent data SSN in tickets, US vs Philippines brand — client asks for US support

- Manager 15hrs QA to 5hrs QA, QA reports CSAT tracking not black box

Options considered

- Keep in-house 4 reps and hire 2 more \$45k each = \$90k/year extra + \$4k tools = \$25k/month total — avoids outsourcing quality drop but over \$12k cap \$15k perfect and took 3 months and quit after 2 months night shifts and backlog 48hrs CSAT 3.8 stays
- SupportNinja \$9k/month 24/7 team 6 with property management experience — meets 24/7 and \$12k cap \$15k perfect all-in, dedicated team, property mgmt exp lease accounting
- Influx \$7.5k/month shared no dedicated team — cheap within \$12k cap but shared not dedicated and no QA reports black box worry
- Televerde \$12k/month US team no 24/7 — US brand good but no 24/7 including weekends and no coverage 6pm-8am, at \$12k cap edge
- VA Philippines \$800/month part-time — cheap but quality low wrong lease accounting, CSAT drop, no SOC2, not 24/7

Tradeoffs

- In-house \$18k now \$25k with 2 more hires vs outsourced \$9k \$7.5k \$12k — in-house control but \$25k/mo over budget and hiring took 3 months and quit after 2 months and 48hr backlog CSAT 3.8, outsourced \$9k meets \$12k cap but quality drop wrong lease accounting risk
- SupportNinja \$9k dedicated 6 property mgmt exp vs Influx \$7.5k shared — \$9k dedicated QA reports vs \$7.5k shared black box cheaper but no dedicated team and CSAT tracking unclear
- 24/7 including weekends vs US only — 24/7 covers 6pm-8am gap and weekends needed for fall leasing but Philippines vs US brand client asks US support
- Tier 1 outsourced Tier 2 in-house vs all outsourced — friend idea outsource Tier 1 keep 2 senior Tier 2 keeps accounting knowledge and escalation to product vs all outsourced loses control churn 3.5% stays
- Monthly contract vs annual — monthly protects if quality fails like VA \$800/mo but costs more vs annual lock \$9k but knowledge loss 2 reps quit no fallback if outsource fails

Risks and concerns

- Quality drop like VA \$800/mo gave wrong lease accounting answers and CSAT 3.8 to worse — 600 tickets 80 chats/day accurate macros needed
- Control loss — outsourced team doesn't know product and churn stays 3.5% vs 2%, escalation to product fails accounting questions
- Data security — rent data and SSN in tickets SOC2 needed — VA no SOC2
- Hidden costs — \$9k quoted then \$3k extra for QA and manager — total over \$12k cap \$15k perfect all-in
- Losing 2 in-house reps who quit last month means knowledge loss if outsource fails and we have no fallback — 2 senior Tier 2 needed
- US vs Philippines brand — client asks for US support and Philippines might hurt brand and CSAT 4.4

Unknowns

- Real total cost — does \$9k/month SupportNinja \$7.5k Influx \$12k Televerde include Zendesk \$500 + Intercom \$400 and QA reports or extra \$3k QA hidden cost over \$12k cap?
- Real quality — will outsourced team give accurate lease accounting macros or wrong answers like VA \$800/mo and CSAT worse than 3.8?

- SOC2 proof — does outsourced have SOC2 for rent data SSN and handle 600 tickets 80 chats/day 24/7 including weekends?
- Escalation path — does Zendesk Slack escalation to product work for accounting questions and keep 2 senior in-house Tier 2?
- CSAT impact — will CSAT go back 4.6 from 3.8 and first response under 2hrs from 48hrs and churn back 2% from 3.5%?
- Contract terms — monthly not annual possible and live by August 1 6 weeks and manager QA 15hrs to 5hrs and QA reports not black box?

Decision criteria

- Tier 1 handling 600 tickets/mo 80 chats/day accurate lease accounting macros not wrong like VA \$800/mo, QA reports CSAT tracking not black box
- 24/7 including weekends live by August 1 6 weeks, first response under 2hrs vs 48hrs now, CSAT above 4.4 back to 4.6 from 3.8
- Cost under \$12k hard cap \$15k perfect monthly all-in including Zendesk \$500 + Intercom \$400 vs \$18k now \$14k salary + \$4k tools, no hidden \$3k extra QA
- Zendesk + Slack escalation to product for accounting, keep 2 senior in-house Tier 2, manager QA 15hrs to 5hrs
- SOC2 for rent data SSN security, monthly contract not annual, US vs Philippines brand acceptable
- Churn back 2% from 3.5%, handle fall leasing season no backlog

Next steps

1. Export Zendesk with 600 tickets/mo and 80 chats/day tags and lease accounting wrong answers from VA \$800/mo and CSAT 3.8 from 4.6 and churn 2% to 3.5% and current \$18k/mo \$14k salary + \$4k tools \$500 Zendesk \$400 Intercom manager 15hrs QA
2. Shortlist 3: SupportNinja \$9k/mo 24/7 team 6 property mgmt exp, Influx \$7.5k shared, Televerde \$12k US — request proposal for Tier 1 600 tickets 80 chats/day accurate lease accounting macros 24/7 weekends Zendesk Slack escalation keep 2 senior Tier 2 QA reports CSAT tracking SOC2 monthly contract live by Aug 1
3. Test quality — give each 10 tickets with lease accounting and time first response under 2hrs vs 48hrs and check macros accurate not wrong like VA and CSAT tracking
4. Get out-the-door pricing under \$12k cap \$15k perfect monthly all-in including Zendesk \$500 + Intercom \$400 and QA and no hidden \$3k extra and monthly not annual and SOC2 proof and escalation to product and manager 5hrs QA
5. Run 2-week paid pilot with 2 senior in-house Tier 2 handling accounting, measure first response under 2hrs, CSAT above 4.4, churn, and decide before Aug 1 fall leasing season

Recommendation

Do not keep in-house 4 reps and hire 2 more \$45k each = \$90k extra + \$4k tools = \$25k/month total if over \$12k cap \$15k perfect and hiring took 3 months and quit after 2 months and backlog 48hrs CSAT 3.8 stays and no 24/7. Do not use VA \$800/mo if wrong lease accounting and no SOC2 rent data SSN and no 24/7 and CSAT worse. Do not buy Influx \$7.5k if shared no dedicated and black box no QA reports CSAT tracking. Do not buy Televerde \$12k if no 24/7 including weekends gap 6pm-8am. Proceed only with outsourced partner under \$12k cap \$15k perfect monthly all-in that proves in 2-week pilot: Tier 1 600 tickets 80 chats/day accurate lease accounting macros, 24/7 weekends live by Aug 1, first response under 2hrs vs 48hrs, CSAT above 4.4 back to 4.6, Zendesk Slack escalation keep 2 senior Tier 2, manager QA 15hrs to 5hrs QA reports not black box, SOC2 rent data SSN, monthly not annual, total under \$12k vs \$18k now including Zendesk \$500 + Intercom \$400, no hidden \$3k QA. If no partner meets all under \$15k, negotiate SupportNinja \$9k/mo to \$12k cap with dedicated team 6 property mgmt exp and monthly contract or consider Tier 1 outsourced Tier 2 in-house hybrid to keep control and churn back 2% from 3.5%.

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